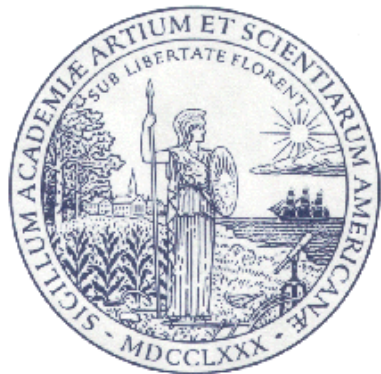




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Stated Meeting Report

Mahler and Ives: Populist Archaism and Musical Innovation

Carl E. Schorske

I

Gustav Mahler and Charles Ives did not fare well with the musical public during their lifetimes. Contemporaries judged both men's music to be, on the one hand, banal and vulgar in substance, on the other, chaotic in form. The hearing of those contemporaries had been schooled by the classical tradition, oriented toward a formal order that developed musical ideas abstractly and autonomously. That tradition was born in the world of Descartes. The Cartesian view of the world saw the surface heterogeneities of the physical universe to be unified by rational principles immanent in Nature. Similarly, the classical system of music posited a rational universe of sound, a tonal order in which laws of harmonic motion could carry one through legitimated dissonance to reconfirm a stable state.

Mahler and Ives, each in his own way, subverted this musical order. They introduced musical materials from the world of everyday in ways that disrupted the purity and autonomy of the closed classical system. Peasant dances and waltzes in Mahler; barn dances and ragtime in Ives; Yiddish and Bohemian tunes in Mahler; patriotic songs and gospel hymns in Ives; and, in both, student songs, marches, military rhythms and trumpet calls: such were the elements from the common life which our two composers deliberately built into their symphonies.

If their contemporaries felt their music "vulgar," they were right. For Mahler and Ives were restoring the banished musics of the

References may be found in the original text.

vulgus, of the commoner, as legitimate constituents of the “highest” forms of music. The classics of music were a music of the upper classes, expressing their ideality. Mahler and Ives widened the social content of the music of the educated, forcing upon them the sound-world of the common people. They did so not outside the forms of the music of the educated, but within them, altering their structures to accommodate the popular elements. In the same era when Nietzsche and Freud opened the intellectual order of reason to the psychological claims of repressed instinct, Mahler and Ives opened the musical order of reason to the repressed musics of the common man, past and present.

The use of vernacular materials did not in itself constitute a break from the classical tradition. After all, virtually all the great composers from Haydn and Mozart to Wagner and Brahms utilized folk themes or rhythms in their music. But they did so by incorporating the folk material fully into the musical logic of classical ideality. They “built in” the borrowed or imitated popular elements, domesticated them to the conventions of classical music. Mahler and Ives, on the other hand, made the listener feel the *autonomy* of the vernacular elements, that which constituted its rudeness, crudeness and strangeness in the house of classical music. They cracked open the canon of musical forms. They crossed the dynamic of the lowly with the regulated movement of the lofty to produce, against the expectations of the classically educated listener, a sense of short-circuit, even of violation. In their separate ways, Mahler and Ives expanded in the language of music the social and ideational content of the modern consciousness, shattering as they went the pure but confining ideas of consistency and coherence that had governed the classical tradition. Vernacular materials became in their hands musical symbols of a more pluralistic society and its experiences, with which to present a multi-layered image of realistic truth. The two composers did this almost simultaneously — they

were born only 14 years apart — in ignorance of each other's work.

II

The boyhoods of Mahler and Ives carry us back to two rather unspectacular provincial towns: Iglau in Moravia, and Danbury, Connecticut. In the late nineteenth century, both cities — and with them, our two protagonists — were caught in the grip of social, ethnic and political changes under the pressures of industrialism. For the Jews of Austria, such as the Mahlers, the changes brought new opportunity for social and physical mobility. Mahler's father took advantage of the civic rights accorded the Jews with the victories of Liberalism to leave his poor Bohemian village. A year after Gustav's birth in 1860, he moved to Iglau, where he established a liquor business.

Long a purely German island in a Czech area, Iglau had been an administrative center to which the more prosperous Czechs of south-east Bohemia regularly sent their sons to study in the German gymnasium. There the Czechs acquired the German culture that was the *sine qua non* to their upward mobility. After 1860, Iglau also became a magnet for the rural poor entering the urban work force. In 1860, the Czechs composed 6 percent of the population; by 1890, 18 percent. Mahler's mother tongue and intellectual education were altogether German, as one would expect of the son of an upwardly mobile Jew. But the environment that furnished his musical consciousness as a child was bicultural. It offered, on the one hand, Czech folk music, often in the grotesque sonorities of the Bohemian wandering bands (*böhmische Musikanten*); on the other, military music provided by Iglau's imperial garrison — from the trumpet calls that punctuated the daily round of military life to the marches and public concerts played by its bands. Mahler once asserted that "in artistic creation, almost none but those impressions received between the ages of four and eleven become decisive and ultimately fruitful." He was well aware

that “the Bohemian music of my childhood went into many of my works [*Sachen*]. . . . In its crudest characteristics [*rohesten Grundzügen*], the national element [in my music] can be heard out of the piping of any Bohemian band.” But the philosophical, poetic and political consciousness that enabled Mahler to endow his provincial musical heritage with a more universal modern meaning he acquired through his German elite education in Vienna. When his parents sent him off to a higher education in classical music in the capital, it was doubtless an act that signified for them — and perhaps for him — another step in the family’s climb up from the bottom of the social ladder. It was also, by cultural analogy, an ascent from the vernacular music of the Bohemian ordinary people to the classical music of the Austrian educated classes.

For Charles Ives and his Danbury, the matter was more complicated. The Ives family was at the other end of the social scale from the lowly Mahlers of Iglau. A large Connecticut clan, the Iveses descended from one of the original settlers of New Haven in 1638. They belonged to the Anglo-American elite that had ruled in Danbury since the 1790s. Charles Ives’ father George (1845-1894) broke ranks from his prominent kinfolk — lawyers, bankers, railroad developers — by becoming the Danbury town musician. Instead of attending Yale, as every male of the Ives family normally did, he took private lessons with an independent teacher, a so-called “professor” of music — a German. George certainly stepped outside the code of his social class in America when he embraced music as a vocation. His son Charles reaped both the musical rewards and the intellectual ambivalences resulting from his father’s bold decision. He was conscious of it all his life.

Contrary to a prevailing myth concerning the impoverishment of American musical culture in the nineteenth century, music probably played as rich and varied a part in the life of Danbury as it did in Iglau. As the town’s chief musician, George Ives was involved in

all of it. He directed and promoted the many kinds of music that accompanied every aspect of public life, and his son Charles came to love it all. As band leader, George Ives celebrated with music the many patriotic festivals that punctuated America's civic-liturgical year. He directed two kinds of religious music: the staid performance-music of the choir for the regular congregation at the Methodist Church; and the gospel hymns for the enthusiastic masses who went to the religious revival meetings in nearby Redding, Connecticut. Of course, George Ives also played dirges for funerals and reels for dances—even for the ball of the Ancient Order of Hibernians, an Irish immigrants' organization. (While Czechs and Jews were moving into Iglau, Irishmen and Italians were coming to Danbury as workers in the hat factories that were replacing the traditional American artisans in that industry.) Not least important, the elder Ives, as conductor of theater orchestras, and as soloist on the cornet or violin, performed pieces from the classical repertory. He gave no pride of place to this so-called "art music," but he knew his harmony and counterpoint, and trained his son in it. He also enlisted Charles to play in his band—and to compose marches for it.

George Ives was what one might call a polymusician, in an America whose culture was not yet as class-differentiated as Europe's then or as ours today. He instructed his gifted boy in the "rules" of high-culture music but inculcated in him a sense that there was nothing sacred about them. He taught Charles to experiment with quarter-tones, and to seek new patterns of sound through dissonance. In sum, George Ives belonged to a world in which music, because it performed many functions in a small society, was also as heterogeneous and porous as the social groups that were its consumers. He cheerfully embraced its many components with no sense that they need be reduced to a single denominator of style or sonority.

Charles Ives absorbed and honored every lesson his father's ingenious, home-grown

musical pluralism had to offer. What struck deepest in him was his father's proud love of America's vernacular music. Charles gradually integrated it into a wider patriotic, populist ideology, and then devised a musical language to convey it. On one crucial issue, however, Charles did not follow his father: he did not embrace music as an artisan vocation. He would not, like George, sacrifice his social status to become a musician of the common life. Charles did the opposite: he chose first a Yale University education, then business as a calling, in conformity with his family's elite status. Music became only an avocation for him. Yet in his musical works, he came to voice a rejection of the modern American elite society he had identified with and affirmed in becoming a businessman.

From boyhood to the end of his life, Ives' attitude toward art music bore the stamp of his American cultural environment: aesthetic culture smacked of femininity. Such culture, especially that which emulated Europe's, was associated with social pretension and with suspect aristocratic leanings. It could be tolerated in women as part of a genteel culture which would lend an aura of refinement to an upper-class household; but it was inappropriate for males, inconsistent with manliness. Vernacular music was virile; classical music feminine. Such was the stereotype common among all classes which Ives imbibed from his small-town boyhood, when he prided himself more on his membership on the Danbury baseball team than on his precocious musical performances. His later indictments of conventional elite music are replete with such terms of contempt as "sofa-cushion formalism" and "sweet," while he scorned its practitioners and public as "soft-ears," "nice ladies," "permanent-wave conductors," "mollycoddle minds."

Anti-feminine and xenophobic, Ives saw in vernacular music an art (he would use the word with hesitation) of rugged, honest strength, in contrast to the classical convention. He set out to make it acceptable to an

elite that was indifferent to it. This led him to create a new kind of musical expression: an eccentric combination of vernacular simplicity, classical intellectuality and avant-garde formal invention.

III

Mahler's education in Iglau certainly did not equip him with a democratic social outlook such as Ives absorbed naturally in Danbury. Though Mahler was of lower social status than Ives, his family's ambitions for him — as well as his own voracious appetite for literature — destined him to be a man of high culture, of *Bildung*, in a society in which all classes honored it. In 1875, when a landed Bohemian patron sent him off to the Vienna Conservatory to prepare his musical career, Mahler's father insisted that he finish his studies at the humanistic gymnasium as well, so that he might become something more than just a technically schooled musician.

It was not in Iglau but through his student associations in Vienna that Mahler acquired his belief in the people. Like many another conservatory student, he fell under the spell of Richard Wagner as a musical liberator from classical restraints. Among the young university intellectuals in the 1870s and 1880s, however, Wagner was idolized for his extra-musical ideas, those concerning the regeneration of German society and culture. Mahler fell in with a remarkable group of such young Wagner devotees, the Pernerstorfer circle. They developed a critique of liberal and capitalist society, espousing a combination of nationalist (*völkisch*) democracy and social reform. In that university circle, Mahler formed his friendship with Victor Adler, later the leader of Austrian Social Democracy. Even more important, Mahler there imbibed the philosophies of Schopenhauer and Nietzsche. These thinkers deepened his sensitivity to psychological experience and to the realm of instinct, and provided him with a philosophic frame for his musical mission. He would create

in sound a new and wider picture of the world with the tensions and heterogeneity they found in it. Thus, from the sophisticated intellectual youth revolt against liberal-rational culture at the end of the 1870s in Vienna, Mahler drew the two principal extra-musical clusters of ideas that were to inspire much of his work as a composer until 1900: *völkisch* populism, and a philosophy that affirmed the world in all its uncohesive and mutable vitality.

Where Mahler's Vienna student years opened to him new worlds of populist ideas hardly accessible in the Iglau of his boyhood, Ives' experience at Yale (1894-1898) was basically the opposite: it led him away from his provincial democratic heritage and deeper into conformity with the secular values of the Anglo-American ascendancy class. Ives entered Yale University in a fallow period of its history. Its time as a serious center of religious and moral education had passed; its time as a serious center of scholarly learning had not yet come. Its real social function was to accomplish the fraternal bonding of the American elite. Ives joined three Yale clubs and made warm friendships that were to advance his later business life. He wrote conventional college songs in the heyday of that genre. Yale had no equivalent to the radical politics (whether of the right or left) that saturated Mahler's university in Vienna. Ives' only recorded political act in college was to write a campaign song for McKinley in 1896. A few words are worth quoting. They address the gold currency issue so central in the contest between McKinley and William Jennings Bryan:

What we want is Honest Money
Good as gold and pure as honey;
Every dollar sound and true. . . .

In music too, Yale schooled Ives well in the ruling convention. But in that case, the yield was a significant addition to his paternal legacy in forming him as an artist. Ives' teacher of theory and composition, Horatio Parker, was a prominent member of the German-educated

“Second New England School” of classical music. Thoroughly unsympathetic to Ives’ beloved musical vernacular, Parker cultivated his student’s mastery of symphonic writing in the manner of its most recent European exponents, Brahms and Dvorak. Ives’ First Quartet, and even more his First Symphony, a graduation exercise, show the marks of this training.

What then was the effect of their student years on our two composers? Mahler was radicalized by Vienna. He gained musical, political and philosophical liberation from the conventional culture of the upwardly mobile in Austria. Ives learned at Yale the elite cultural values and techniques of classical composition that his American provincial background had disvalued. Both composers absorbed in higher education an ideological reinforcement of their respective class origins—Mahler’s low and Ives’ high; but they did so in ways that complemented and enriched their previous cultural and musical orientations—Mahler by adding folkish populism to his classical training; Ives by adding the classical legacy to his vernacular heritage. Thus both found in their higher education a complement to their respective provincial inheritances that would enable them to synthesize the popular and elite components of their social worlds in a new kind of music.

IV

On his graduation from Yale in 1898, Charles Ives went to New York to launch his business career. How typical of his class and time was the pattern of his life in young manhood! Two relatives well placed in the Mutual Insurance Company procured him a job in their firm. For a decade, Ives shared with a group of Yale alumni friends a bachelor apartment they jocularly called “Poverty Flat.” Even his future wife, Harmony Twitchell, came to Charles through this small charmed circle—a wife who, to be sure, was to prove a stalwart psychological support to his musical

eccentricity. Harmony was the daughter of a prominent minister of Hartford, a close friend of Mark Twain.

Ives' career as an insurance agent gave him not only financial success but also ethical satisfaction. For he defined his business sincerely as a service to help the family man, assuring himself that life insurance was, as he wrote, "doing its part in the progress of greater life values." Ives pioneered in so-called "scientific programming" in insurance, designed to help a client plan for the security of his family without exceeding his means. At a time of great financial scandals in America's burgeoning corporate insurance industry, Ives and his long-time partner defined themselves as upright small businessmen serving ordinary individual clients, including immigrants.

Ives felt no contradiction between his deep commitment to business and his devotion to music. In fact, his old-fashioned ideal from his Danbury inheritance, the virtue of the common life, seems to have gathered new strength from his New York experience. He detested the professionalization of music then growing visible in New York, just as he came to detest businessmen who had no civic responsibility, no ethic but the big money. He resisted as well the autonomy of art. "The fabric of existence weaves itself whole," he said. "You cannot set art off in a corner and hope for it to have vitality, reality, substance. There can be nothing 'exclusive' about a substantial art. It comes directly out of the heart of life and thinking about life and living life. My work in music helped my business and my business helped my music." Ives made an example of Debussy, whom he saw as original but lifeless: "...Debussy's content would have been worthier of his manner, if he had hoed corn or sold newspapers for a living, for in this way he might have gained a deeper vitality and truer theme to sing at night and of a Sunday."

The unity of art and life, like the unity of business and the commonwealth, was increasingly contradicted by Ives' experience in America's class society. The specific form in

which the class society showed itself in music, as in the theater, was the growing cleavage between high and low culture. Ives set himself the task of reuniting the two cultures in music—bridging, in effect, Danbury vernacular and Yale-New York elite culture, at the very moment when history was decisively rending them apart. As composer, he pursued this work in several stages, each one taking him deeper into an idealized American past, or higher into a transcendent utopian future.

The first phase of Ives' life as a composer had begun in earnest at Yale and extended into his early business years when he defined himself socially as part of the educated elite. At that time Ives mastered the classical sonata form, and, in effect, gave himself over to serious music modelled on the "German music" that was then gaining favor in America. But Ives pursued his aim in a special way, namely, to impregnate European classical forms with the cultural substance of the American people from a time when class divisions, in culture as in society, were less pronounced.

Ives' Second Symphony, begun in college but finished in New York in 1902, shows how he went about elevating American popular substance. He did not create a wholly new musical language, but made meaning by combining American idioms with European classical ones, casting the whole in classical form. The Second opens with a theme reminiscent of the great hymn for cellos from the final movement of Brahms' First, but as the development proceeds, more and more American materials are folded in. A sturdy gospel hymn, "Bringing in the Sheaves," rises out of the Brahmsian subject, and this in turn yields to a wistful college song, "Where, O Where, Is the Pea-green Freshman?" Before the first movement ends with a climactic Wagnerian treatment of "My Maryland" (it has prevailed over "Dixie"), Ives has, with his musical quotations, boxed the compass of American life: religion, patriotism, popular dance, Northern and Southern regional culture. The forms and even the instrumentation are "a la

Brahms"—as Ives later recorded, with some impatience, "at Parker's [his Yale teacher's] suggestion." Yet the materials, almost all drawn from the vernacular, are strung together in a linear sequence resembling a traditional form of nineteenth-century American music, the organ "voluntary," an improvised potpourri of marches, sacred music, popular tunes, fugues and opera arias, interspersed with chromatic variations or free fantasias. In the Second Symphony, Ives' array of contents suggested the voluntary, yet he contained them in classical form.

The bridge that Ives built in the Second Symphony between classical and vernacular music was too radical to reach the concert public. Yet it was too close to European musical convention for the developing outlook of Ives himself. During the first decade of his New York life, he suffered increasingly from a double alienation: from the "cultured" musical world; and from the whole elite of which he was a part. Social isolation, intellectual regression, and musical innovation fed upon each other.

Although he remained an active and committed insurance man, Ives could not bring himself to live out the social role of the successful young executive, with its service on charitable boards or in conservative civic causes. Instead, especially after his marriage in 1908, he withdrew into his composing. Retreating into the world of his Danbury boyhood and the American past, Ives constructed in his historical imagination a kind of lost paradise. His music became a celebration of the life of a vanishing America that he himself had left behind.

In countless songs for which he wrote many of the texts himself, Ives presented American community life through the eyes and ears of a small boy: the excitement of waiting for a theater performance to begin, a circus parade, vignettes of small-town characters with their idiosyncrasies, patriotic festivals—even historical episodes pictured in the pageantry with which a boy might relive them in his

imagination. The image of the American boy as a symbol of national health and innocence was not uncommon to American writers of Ives' time. Mark Twain's *Huck Finn* and Tom Sawyer, and Booth Tarkington's *Penrod* were among the boy-heroes who functioned as "natural" critics of modern U.S. society, especially of its pretentious elite and their highfalutin' European culture. The American boy incarnated the old virtues: masculinity, simplicity, forthrightness, egalitarianism.

The more Ives looked backward to the past, the more avant-garde his music became. Within the frame of his boyhood ideal, he began to unfold formal and harmonic freedom in music. No longer did he attempt, as in the *Second Symphony*, to put his American "manhood" in European dress. In place of the symphony he generated a new form that he called the "orchestral set." The set contained separate tonal pictures, often composed at different times, loosely strung together, like *tableaux vivants* (on a single idea). Thus his "New England Holidays" (1904-1913) links four separate pieces on major patriotic festivals "based on something of the memory that a man has of his boyhood holidays." The many quoted tunes appear often fragmented, distorted and dizzily superimposed as they might appear in the mental process of recollection of the multitude of experiences that a holiday could bring: a parade, a dance, a love encounter, etc. Flouting convention also meant for Ives, among other things, the liberation of dissonance and the creation of simultaneous, non-concordant rhythms. His dissonances were not conceived as a system, but as a simultaneous presence of non-homogeneous elements in a single field of sound—like the irregular integration of rocks, trees and plants on a wild hillside.

In life, especially in social life, the reality Ives saw was plurality, but he affirmed the plurality as unity. Out of the many voices of the American past he strove to create unity in music: dissonant, often jangling, but of one substance for him who had the will to make

free associations instead of insisting on imposed order. The boyhood vision of a rich but not fully regulated world certainly spurred and legitimated Ives in enlarging the scope of music beyond convention, even while it reinforced his historical nostalgia, his archaistic fidelity to ante-bellum New England.

Ives found support for his pluralistic nativism in the Concord philosophers, Emerson and Thoreau. They too had rejected "the courtly muses of Europe." Ives embraced their anti-institutional criticisms and their anti-systemic Nature cult as part of his effort to overcome his own elitism. Thoreau, wrote Ives, "distinguished between the complexity of nature, which teaches freedom, and the complexity of materialism, which teaches slavery." With Thoreau, Ives escaped from the pressures of time into the more enduring world of space. In place of the usual succession of events that gives Western music its temporal character and thrust, Ives created an almost tectonic world of sound. He evoked in the listener a sense of physical space, with palpable distances between simultaneous musical events, each one transpiring in its own field.

Ives' taste for ante-bellum, anti-conventional philosophy complemented his historical values, incarnated in a pantheon of historical heroes: the Puritan fathers, the Abolitionists and Lincoln. The Civil War became his heroic age. Here family piety reinforced his radical-democratic traditionalism in focusing on the blacks as a kind of touchstone of American civic structure and health. Charles' grandfather had been a militant abolitionist; in 1908 the composer memorialized his cause in a piece called "The Anti-abolition Riots in Danbury." About 1912, Ives celebrated a Negro Regiment that had fought in the Civil War in a choral piece for the First Orchestral Set. He wrote his own verse for the work, identifying deeply with the black soldiers:

Moving — Marching — Faces of Souls!
Marked with Generations of pain,
Part-Freers of a Destiny,

Slowly, restlessly swaying us on with you
Towards other Freedom!

The more articulate Ives grew in his patriotic idealism, the more distant he became from the actual political options of his time. During the presidential campaign of 1912, he composed a crassly dissonant song, expressing disgust with the three candidates—Wilson, Taft and Roosevelt—in “the same chord hit over and over . . . a sad chord, a hopeless chord, a chord of futility.” He had come a long road since writing his campaign song for McKinley in 1896. Not until the coming of World War I would a connection be reopened between his archaistic visions and the contemporary political scene. Meanwhile, Ives had found modern musical forms to express his historical counter-image to contemporary America and its “Europeanized” class culture.

V

“The *Wunderhorn* Years”: such is the term generally used to designate the first period of Mahler’s mature creative work, spanning the last fifteen years of the nineteenth century. The term lifts to view the collection of folk poems, *Des Knaben Wunderhorn*, that Mahler used extensively to project his populist values into musical language. Mahler appreciated this verse not so much for its nationalist import as for its existential realism, a realism born out of the raw social experience of the people, much of it in the ‘Thirty Years’ War. The proto-Brechtian directness of popular experience in *Des Knaben Wunderhorn* cut deeper in its psychological realism than the bookish, myth-oriented folk nationalism of Wagner. It provided Mahler with poetic material bearing a natural kinship to the vernacular musics of his Iglau childhood. With these and the larger store of ideas acquired in his crucial years of exposure to Vienna’s young generation of social-populist rebels, Mahler was armed as a composer to break out of the confines of established musical culture which as a conduc-

tor he so faithfully served.

One would expect Mahler to feel less tension between composing and conducting than Charles Ives did between composing and business. Yet the “fabric of life” did not “weave itself whole,” to use Ives’ words again, any more for Mahler than for Ives. Mahler’s stunning success in his career as opera director came increasingly into conflict with his deepest vocation as composer: to create in music what he called a “*Weltbild*,” a true picture of the world as he experienced it.

Mahler’s *Weltbild* bore the marks not only of intellectual populism but of his class and ethnic origins. Early in life, he formed a self-image that never left him: that of a wanderer — the very antithesis of Ives, with his deep sense of Yankee roots. No institutional success could relieve Mahler of the sense of being an outsider. Despite a conversion to Catholicism in 1897, which was sincere as well as advantageous, he never forgot as an adult a dream he had had at the age of eight, in which he identified himself with Ahasuerus, the Wandering Jew. In his first major song cycle (1884), Mahler used a class image, that of the journeyman, to represent the rootless one he felt himself to be. Entitling his cycle *Songs of a Wandering Journeyman*, Mahler described it as rendering the experience of “a journeyman who . . . after a blow of fate, goes out into the world and now wanders aimlessly.” The social ambiguity of Mahler as populist and marginal intellectual is evident also in the texts. Some he wrote himself, in the folk style; one he incorporated into the cycle from the *Knaben Wunderhorn*, as if to complete his identification with the folk-substance.

In his First Symphony, Mahler’s ambiguous cultural position shows forth both in the selection of musical materials and in the way they are deployed. To convey the idea that governed the project, the experience of the world of a sensitive, anguished and passionate hero, Mahler used song themes of his own from the “Wandering Journeyman.” The world the hero encounters, however, is that of the common

man, and here Mahler employs the vernacular. By placing in succession quotations from well-defined popular musics with strong emotional and social connotations, Mahler could link death and mockery, joy and fear, crudeness and refinement in a shocking temporal juxtaposition. In the third movement of the First Symphony, Mahler transforms the folk song "Frère Jacques," with its theme of the boy who does not rise betimes to attend to his social duties, into a funeral march. The merry chiding of the lazy boy of the original folk version thus becomes deadly serious. Yet the earnest dirge in turn flows into raucous tunes from the Czech and Yiddish vernacular that, with brazen indifference, turn the march of death into a crude dance of life. In Mahler's picaresque procession of emotion-laden states, no mood tarries long. The listener is whipsawed between compassion and laughter, tenderness and terror as the multi-hued spectacle of life unfolds.

After conducting his First Symphony in New York, Mahler wrote of his early symphonies, "I feel very strange about these works when I conduct them. A searingly painful feeling crystallizes [in me]: What a world that is, that gives birth to such sounds and shapes as its projected image!"

What a world indeed! In substance, Mahler's image of it consisted of a multitude of heterogeneous elements, a musical vocabulary drawn from different ethnic and cultural traditions, high and low, in a vast social and national turmoil. Mahler organized that vocabulary by a kind of serial association to form a continuous metamorphic flow, reflecting the erratic character of experience and the elision of its elements. In the culture of *fin-de-siècle* Austria, the relation between ego and world, mind and reality had become problematical for the intellectual class, causing subject and object to flow into each other. Mahler expressed that condition in music by blurring the boundary between symphony and song. His musical realism was richer and more socially heterogeneous in its symbolic referents

than the classic symphonic tradition had allowed; yet he presented that uncohesive, pluralized reality as *experienced*, with the kind of personal intensity that belonged to depth-psychology in substance, and to the art song as musical genre.

Mahler gave his *Weltbild* of the *Wunderhorn* period its most comprehensive statement in the Third and Fourth Symphonies. Like Ives' mature work, Mahler's was philosophical as well as social. The philosopher behind it was Nietzsche. He was to Mahler what Emerson was to Ives. Mahler thought of entitling the Third symphony, "*Meine fröhliche Wissenschaft*" (*My Joyful Science*), borrowing from Nietzsche. He spoke openly of his philosophical intentions for the work, calling it "a musical poem comprehending in a step-by-step intensification all the stages of evolution. . . ." Mahler's symphonic hierarchy of being begins in "Pan's awakening," where the life force frees itself from inert matter. He soon sweeps us into the crude, heavy vitality of Nietzsche's Dionysian primordial world, as set forth in *The Birth of Tragedy*. Mahler follows Nietzsche again in conjoining Dionysian intoxication with Apollonian dream (Mahler calls it "a summernight's dream"), making possible the affirmation of life in all its joy and pain. And at the very center of the Third Symphony, Mahler placed, as the voice of human wisdom, Zarathustra's "Drunken Song of Midnight." The song expresses what Schopenhauer called "the pain of individuation," a pain which Nietzsche—and Mahler—accepted as the ground of existence along with the desire to overcome it by dissolving the boundary between ego and world.

In the Third Symphony, avowedly philosophic though it was, Mahler revealed more visibly than ever his un-Nietzschean commitment to popular experience. In the opening movement, to represent the raw-instinctual, the coarse, vigorous thrust of Dionysian vitality, Mahler employs vernacular-style march and dance musics. And after this Dionysian force has been affirmed in the prophetic vision

of Zarathustra (the fourth movement), he invokes the folk once more, this time in a new spirit of community *joie-de-vivre* in a final choral movement on a verse from *Des Knaben Wunderhorn*.

The crown of Mahler's philosophic *theatrum mundi* is the Fourth Symphony. Sometimes called Mahler's "Pastoral," the Fourth develops a kind of Biedermeier utopia in music, in which folk fantasy proclaims the victory of the pleasure principle and the affirmation of the gratified life.

The Biedermeier simplicity and comfortable naiveté of the Fourth Symphony as a whole invites comparison with Ives' small-town American pastoral. Was not Mahler celebrating childhood as Ives celebrated boyhood? "*Was mir das Kind erzählt*": such was the programmatic idea under which he first conceived the Green-Pasture-like heaven of the Fourth. Both composers embraced the past and the child together, yet in different ways. Ives espoused enthusiastic, innocent boyhood as part of the American life he wished to preserve. In recreating the boy, he celebrated a specific cultural order. Mahler, on the other hand, embraced the child and the *Wunderhorn* folk fantasy of heaven associated with it, not as an historical paradise lost, but as a universal dream of a state of gratified desire, a timeless birthright of mankind.

The trajectory of development I have described has brought our two composers from their small-town provincial beginnings, through their urban intellectual and social formation, to their maturity as composers who found their voices in the mission of enlarging the range of classical music. Their different kinds of populism enabled them to embrace the wider life of a pluralized society, to expand their cultural consciousness, and to create a new music to express it.

Mahler completed his Nietzschean-populist *Weltbild* in 1900; Ives, fourteen years his junior, had constructed his communitarian utopia by 1914. In 1900 and 1914 respectively, both men stood *nel mezzo del camin*'. Both

now entered life crises that pointed them in new directions in their world-views and consequently in their musics. Mahler left the outer social world behind to become, like other Viennese, an explorer of the interior life. Ives, shaken out of his American past-orientation by World War I, turned his idealistic vision toward the future as a radical Wilsonian universalist. Mahler in turning inward to the suffering self, Ives in turning outward to a brave new world, both composers could draw upon the rich musical language they had created as *fin-de-siècle* champions of the common man.

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